

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit III – Ideation and Creative Thinking · Presentation 3 of 6

Mind Mapping

What a mind map is · how to build one · mind maps and concept maps · where it earns its keep · turning a map into themes

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In this presentation

- What a mind map is
- A worked example
- How to build one
- Mind map and concept map
- Four places it earns its keep
- From map to themes
- Paper and digital
- Common mistakes



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What a mind map is

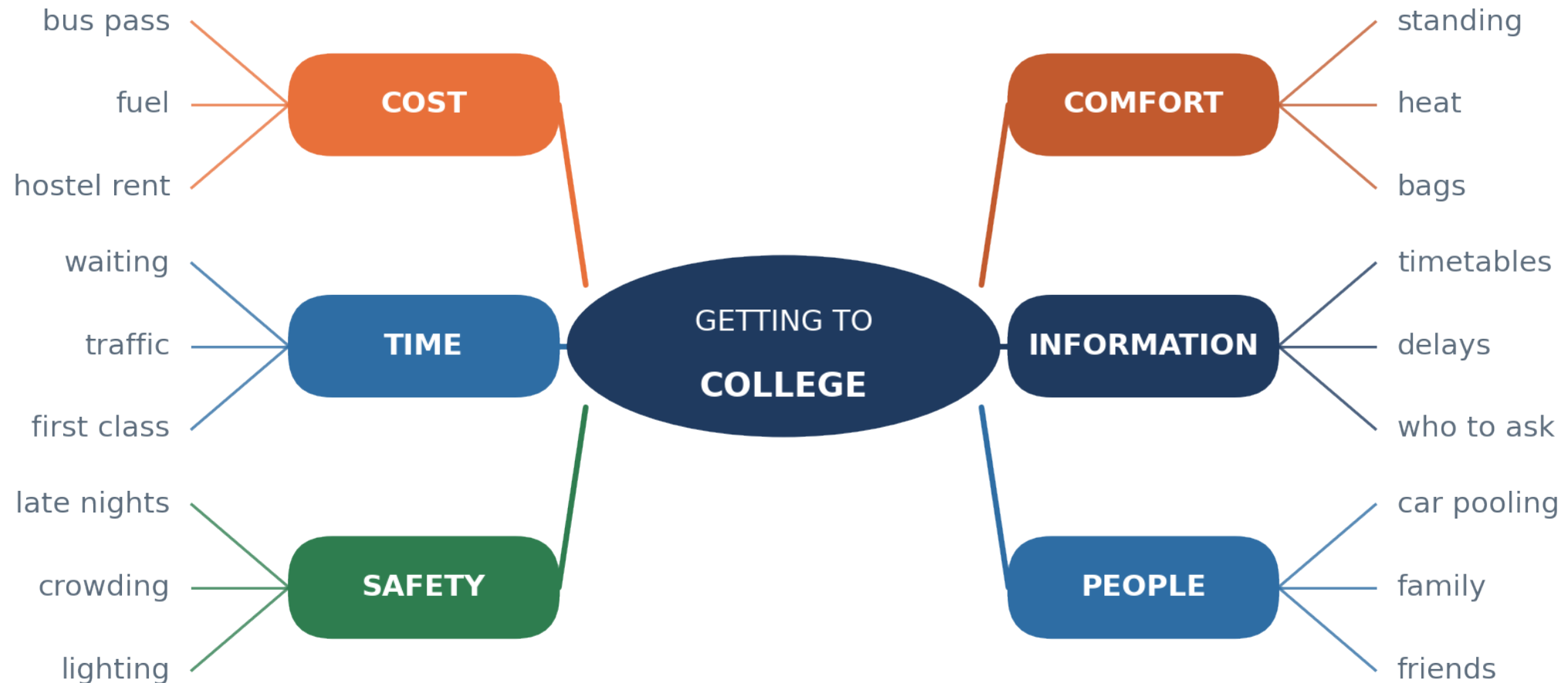
Letting the structure emerge instead of deciding it first

What a mind map is

- A radial diagram: one central idea, main branches, and sub-branches off those
- Popularised by Tony Buzan through the BBC series Use Your Head in 1974
- Keywords, not sentences – one word or short phrase to a branch
- Colour and position are structural, not decoration; they keep the branches apart

KEY POINT A list forces an order you may not have yet. A mind map lets the structure appear while you write.

A worked example



One problem, six branches – and the short branches are the interesting ones.

How to build one

- Turn the page landscape and start in the centre with the topic
- Main branches radiate outwards – keep them to five or seven
- One keyword to a branch; add sub-branches the moment they occur to you
- Work fast and do not correct; a messy first map is doing exactly its job

ACTIVITY Ten minutes. Build a map of your team's problem alone and in silence, then lay all the maps side by side and compare the branches.

Mind map and concept map

Mind map

- One central topic
- Radial, tree-shaped
- Branches are keywords
- For opening a topic up

Concept map

- Several concepts at once
- A network, not a tree
- Links are labelled verbs
- For explaining a system

KEY POINT Use a mind map to open a topic up. Use a concept map to show somebody else how a system works.

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Using it in design

From an open topic to named themes you can ideate against

Four places it earns its keep

Unpacking a problem

Put the problem in the centre and find out how many dimensions it actually has.

Generating ideas

Each branch becomes its own direction to generate against, one at a time.

Clustering findings

Turn a wall of field notes from Unit II into themes you can name and use.

Planning the work

Break a project into branches, then hang owners and dates off each one.

From map to themes

- Branches that grew long show where your thinking already was
- Branches that stayed short show where you have not looked yet
- Circle the crossings – the same idea on two branches is a theme
- Name each theme in a sentence and carry it forward as a How Might We

KEY POINT The short branches are the interesting ones. They mark the parts of the problem nobody in the team has thought about.

Paper and digital

- Paper is faster, more physical, and better for a team standing round one table
- Digital is easier to rearrange, to share and to keep – and never runs out of space
- A tool tempts you to tidy at exactly the moment you should still be generating
- Map on paper first; move it into a tool only once the structure has settled

KEY POINT Tidying is converging. Do not let a tool make you converge while you should still be opening up.

Common mistakes

- Writing sentences where a keyword would do
- Deciding the branches before you start, so nothing new can appear
- Making it beautiful instead of making it long
- Stopping at the first level, where nothing surprising ever lives

THINK ABOUT IT

Look at your map. Which branch is shortest – and why did you not think about it?

- Is it short because it does not matter, or because you do not know it?
- Who would know more about that branch than you do?
- What would you find out in one hour of asking?
- What would the map look like if that branch were the centre?

Summary

- A mind map is radial: one centre, branches, sub-branches, keywords only
- Buzan popularised it in 1974; the form is far older
- Work fast, do not correct, and keep branches to five or seven
- Mind maps open a topic; concept maps explain a system
- Long branches show what you know, short ones what you have missed
- Name each theme in a sentence and carry it into ideation

Next: The SCAMPER technique

- Where SCAMPER came from
- The seven prompts and what each one asks
- A worked example on something you use every day
- When SCAMPER works, and when it does not